

TAG Data Challenge Proposal

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The Spark Effect



What is Ableism?



Ableism is a set of beliefs or practices that devalue and discriminate against people with physical, intellectual, or psychiatric disabilities and often rests on the assumption that disabled people need to be ‘fixed’. Ableism is intertwined in our culture, due to many limiting beliefs about what disability does or does not mean, how able-bodied people learn to treat people with disabilities and how they are often not included at the table for key decisions.



Disability Statistics

In America, more than 1 in 4 individuals have a disability that range from visual or auditory impairments to cognitive or physical disabilities

Disabling Hearing Loss Statistics

Nationally



- ~38 million Americans have a significant hearing loss
- About 2 to 3 out of every 1,000 children in the United States are born with a detectable level of hearing loss in one or both ears
- The prevalence of hearing loss increases with age, among those older than 60 years, over 25% are affected by disabling hearing loss



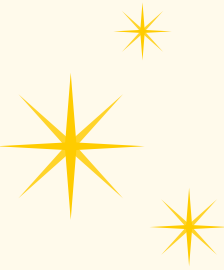
Georgia

- 373,000 people in the state of Georgia have a hearing disability
 - By gender: 211,200 men and 161,800 women
 - By race: 258,100 white, 72,400 Black, 1,200 Native American, 8,300 Asian, 33,000 Other





Current Landscape: *What Exists*



Federal Protections

Federal policy such as ADA, Section 504, and IDEA have expanded inclusion and accessibility through accommodations in key areas



Community-Based Programs

Programs and organizations such as Deaf Bridges to Recovery and Hands & Voices are dedicated to serving the needs of deaf and hard of hearing people to optimize outcomes and empower them

Assistive & Communication Technology

Products, tools, and systems such as assistive listening systems, captions, and speech-to-text that enhance communication and independence

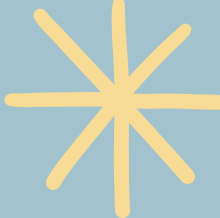
Key Issues Within the Deaf and HoH Community

- Limited access to language and communication for deaf individuals of all ages in various settings
- 50 deaf individuals to 1 interpreter, leading to significant access challenges
- Lack of qualified and experienced professionals is leading to delays for on-site appointments, meetings and events

- Number of long COVID cases, availability of remote work and general dissatisfaction with working conditions and compensation
- Despite advancements in communication accessibility tools, there is still limited access to language and communication for deaf individuals in various settings



Challenges to Accessibility



Data Unavailability

Inadequate data on health, outcomes, and demographics make it difficult to make data-driven decisions and interventions



Communication Access

Insufficiency of qualified professionals, assistive listening devices, and communication tools for full and equal participation

Stigma & Misconceptions

Cultural and structural barriers promote exclusion that limit opportunities for inclusivity and accessibility that impact health and wellbeing



Resource Inaccessibility

Program availability and accessibility are disproportionate, leaving rural and other underserved areas to lack programs and resources



Why Does it Matter?

Inclusion is the practice or policy of providing equal access to opportunities and resources for people who might otherwise be excluded or marginalized



Historical and ongoing prejudices about deafness have created barriers that limit full participation in education, employment, cultural spaces, and social interaction for people with disabling hearing loss

Problem Statement

Across Georgia, individuals with hearing loss continue to face barriers which can limit full participation in education, employment, healthcare, transportation, and civic engagement. Using data analysis, we will:

1. **Identify** which efforts have delivered the most measurable improvements in quality of life, independence, and inclusion.
2. **Evaluate** the reach and impact of disability-related training, programs and advocacy initiatives
3. **Determine** existing gaps/unmet needs and identify programs with the highest priority



Proposed Approach



Perform a current state assessment of existing programs that serve the deaf and hard of hearing community



Develop a culturally sensitive program/curriculum for the deaf and HoH community that encompasses the various identities and cultural backgrounds they possess



Conduct an annual survey of the deaf and HoH community in Georgia that captures information such as socioeconomic status, race, gender, age and language(s) spoken at home

- Develop a scorecard that evaluates the effectiveness of programs to understand what programs exist that actually matter
- Identify which programs have poor outcomes and determine areas for opportunity



Methodology



Community Impact

Informed Decision Making

- Access to data helps decision makers understand the needs of Georgia's deaf and hard of hearing community

Cultural Relevant Support

- Adopting a more culturally relevant pedagogy influences social interactions, demonstrating linguistic competence and intercultural competence



Did you know?

BASL exhibits unique *phonological*, *lexical*, and *syntactic* features that reflect its users' distinct experiences and cultural identities!

Available Data

- ASL Interpreters in Georgia
- Registry of Interpreters for the Deaf
- Selected Social Characteristics in the United States (US Census)
- Interpreter Training Programs in the United States



Data Considerations

- **Collecting Data**: Costs are lower or non-existent if you choose an open source tool or software package
- **Data Privacy**: Securing PII by encrypting or anonymizing your data



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Team Members



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